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RESEARCH REPORT

Literacy for Migrants: an ethnography of literacy acquisition among nomads of Kutch

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Introduction

Literacy for Migrants was conceived as a response to discussions with nomads met during other fieldwork in Gujarat, Western India (Dyer, 1993) about their difficulties in getting their children to attend school because of their migratory way of life: and adults' problems because they were unable to read their ration cards, bus destination boards, or correspond with their relatives. The Rabaris (numbering some 90,000) are one of the biggest nomadic groups in Kutch (a District of Gujarat, Fig. 1) and, like nomads all over the world, their way of life is coming under increasing pressure because of the industry-based pattern of 'development' (Bardhan, 1984; Agrawal, 1992; Vira, 1993; Rao, 1994;) which is rapidly subsuming their sources of fodder and water.

Research into literacy which adopts a sociological perspective can usefully explore the relationship between literacy and social power relations (Oxenham, 1980; Street, 1984; 1987; Cook-Gumperz, 1986), and we hypothesised that nomads' unusual relationship with 'mainstream' society would be an insightful case study, not least because they are a highly independent group who value social apartness and for whom, until recently, any form of formal education has been irrelevant.

We proposed, therefore, to construct an 'ethnography of literacy acquisition' over a time-scale of 2½ years. Our core concerns were not only to understand the meanings of literacy for the Rabaris; in the long term, we hoped also to contribute to theoretical understandings of literacy acquisition, of literacy and action research methods, and to provide policy inputs.

We would first document the social context of this nomadic community: its social organisation, cultural conventions, decision-making traditions, migratory patterns, economic conditions, levels of formal education and/or literacy, interactions with external literate and numerate conventions, etc. From this wider context, we wanted to understand what education, formal schooling and literacy means to this community. We then intended, in the second year, to work with a smaller group, to test whether

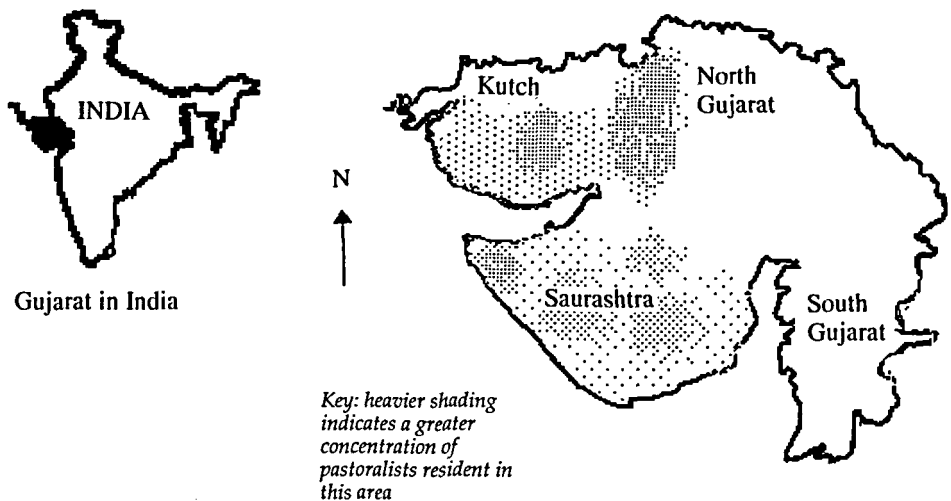


FIG. 1. Pastoral zones in Gujarat.

peripatetic teaching was (a) appropriate and (b) feasible, using literacy materials that were developed in line with Rabari social conventions.

At the design stage, our major focus was on the 'action' part of the project when, after a year of background work, we expected to migrate with one group and document their process of becoming literate. It did not turn out this way: ground realities were both more complex and very different from what we anticipated, and the second year saw a major change in research strategy—a shift from a migrant group to a sedentary one, although still from the Rabari community.

Formal education is a 'modern' institution and, whether directly or indirectly, as a symbol of a changing world, it presents a threat to the pastoral lifestyle. As we worked with pastoral groups, we often found ourselves at the point of intersection between the modern world, which we represented, and the Rabari value framework which is under ever-increasing pressure to conform to that modern world. This revealed a discrepancy between pastoralists' almost universal conceptual acceptance of literacy, and the realities of accepting the social and other changes that becoming literate would imply, along with multiple confusions about what education, schooling and literacy might be. We probed how the nomadic value framework accommodates the whole notion of education; and, if education is a part of modern society, how that framework copes with the changes that participating in the modern world, even if only on its fringes, demands.

Why Pastoralists need Education and/or Literacy

Along with other 'weak' sections of society, pastoralists are affected by 'development' policies geared to advance the mainstream, but inadvertently marginalising traditional land users. The impact of exploitative development strategies on the rural environment is becoming increasingly evident in the degradation and deforestation of land, and excessive 'chemicalisation' of agriculture (Rao, 1994). As one of the most marginalised social groups, pastoralists have no voice in a development process that has profoundly negative consequences for them. Most of the interactions that pastoralists have with the outside world carry implicitly negative messages about their status, particularly in the

case of the sheep and goat herders with whom we worked. Their contribution to the economy is hardly recognised; their animals are seen as non-productive and no facilities are extended to them in times of need, i.e. drought. Worse, they are blamed for the destructive habits of their animals, which come to light because of the multiple pressures they and others generate on their traditional fodder resources. They are gradually being edged out of the agricultural equation, where they now represent a potential threat to be contained on terms dictated by farmers; and they are constantly denied access to grasslands within forest areas by officers who are operating a system that responds better to bribes than rules. Pastoralists' ignorance of the modern market economy, with its competition and profit imperatives, means that their understanding of fluctuating prices is poor, so they constantly suspect that they are being cheated by merchants. Interactions with doctors, police and other government officials, etc. are all intimidating because pastoralists do not know the rules of the modern institutions they represent.

In all these encounters, larger society drums in two overall messages: that pastoralists are a nuisance, and that they would not have these problems if they were 'educated'. They themselves feel powerless, and inadequately informed about how the wider world works to be able to deal with these situations competently. Being 'uneducated' is closely associated with being made to feel backward:

Because we are uneducated, people can put things one way or another. If someone sidetracks or sets us on the wrong way, we won't know. We have become backward and so we have remained backward. (personal communication, Mangabhai Rabari, 1994)

Pastoralists, inevitably, perceive the world around them to be increasingly hostile: many of their values are challenged, particularly since they are at odds with the credo of market-oriented consumerism. They participate only marginally in modernising society, where survival and success are largely driven by social status and/or formal education, which they do not possess. As external tensions increase, the obvious option pastoralists consider is the potential of education—i.e. formal, school education—in improving their own position.

Literacy is in part seen as an outcome of going to school; but the practical applications of being able to read and write are recognised by adults, who would like these skills for themselves. Paradoxically, one of the few modern developments that really benefits them—the public transport system—is one that vexes them, for they cannot read bus boards or tickets, and feel their independence and pride is compromised by having to ask another to do so.

This kind of thinking about education and literacy was evident among Rabaris when we were conducting our investigation. Some nomadic parents had tried to get their children to go to village schools, but this experience of village schools is generally disappointing, with few children staying on to begin secondary schooling; there was no adult literacy. School education was fairly widespread among the children of the semi-sedentary Katchi group, but few adults were literate. Our work was therefore in an ethnic group which has no precedent of school education, and very limited understandings of the uses to which either schooling or literacy can be put.

Literacy among Transhumant Pastoralists

The first year was spent with transhumant pastoralists, setting up pilot peripatetic teaching experiments. We worked in two areas and opted not to pursue work in

Saurashtra, where pastoralists are currently fighting to gain Scheduled Tribe status: with this official status come several advantages, one of which is perceived to be improved rights in pressing ownership to traditional fodder sources. The need for education was discussed—they wanted government to provide boarding schools for their children—but adults did not feel that education for themselves was nearly as important as changing their political status. The idea of schooling or literacy as something in any sense emancipating or empowering in this struggle did not exist. In practical terms, too, migratory patterns in this area would not have allowed us to work with a group large enough to justify the effort, since their migratory groups often split down to just a nuclear family.

In Kutch, leaders were interested in school education as a means of developing the community, and supportive of our efforts to establish an appropriate, peripatetic, mode of teaching. All the pastoralists we interviewed talked of a need for literacy, and for schooling, and cited instances where not being able to read and write caused difficulties. At no time was there any suggestion of resistance to the notion of education—the attention of those who wanted education focused solely on the logistical difficulties of providing it, and the conflict between caring for animals and having time to study.

Identification of Pilot Migratory Group

Towards the middle of the first year, we were able to gain the trust of two transhumant groups. Our long-term intention was to identify individuals who would integrate us into a group the following season (group membership fluctuates from year to year), with whom we intended to travel for at least 3 months. In the short term, we wanted to observe at first hand the nomadic way of life, analyse the possibilities and constraints of teaching on migration, and collect data which we would use to inform both our understandings and the teaching materials we proposed subsequently to develop. The first group was migrating far away from home for the first time and found this stressful; the head man was not supportive of us, although group members were very enthusiastic. In the second group, the head man was most supportive and welcoming to us, and we developed a very good relationship with the whole group, whose members were very excited about becoming literate. By now, we had identified key persons, had adequate insights into their way of life to inform the next phase of our work, and established that what we proposed was feasible.

In the course of migrating with these groups, we were able to identify their literacy needs, which were limited to bus destination boards and tickets, and reading and writing letters. Their desire to read and write was always framed in terms of them being able to avoid having to ask someone else to assist them. Illiteracy was an affront to personal dignity, while the ability to read and write was seen as an asset which would allow anyone to cope with any situation.

We learned a good deal about the social context of the literacy learning, and of these pastoralists' interactions with wider society. In general, only the male group leader (*mukhi*) has any sustained contact with other social groups, as he negotiates the next site on which they will camp. The little contact men generally have with other communities is not particularly positive: we watched policemen trying to extort payments for no reason; and farmers being very patronising and rude to them. Rabari women's interactions with village women are mostly limited to meeting at the common well, and are strictly functional. Outsiders tend to have a negative image of Rabaris, which runs counter to the image Rabaris have of themselves; as being of high social status because

of their high position in the Hindu caste hierarchy. Ascribed status is gradually becoming less relevant in interactions with wider society, where education contributes to the beginning of a secularising social order in which education is important.

The exigencies of their occupation, their determination to retain their own values, and the rather negative interaction with outsiders means that the Rabaris' own social reference group forms an almost exclusive focus in their lives: the migratory *dhang* is at once an economic and a social unit. The wish to remain apart from others is a pronounced Rabari characteristic that has extremely important practical and conceptual consequences for the introduction of both formal education and literacy. It was indicative of their strong desire to rectify what they saw as backwardness imposed by their inability to attend school that the groups, normally closed to an outsider, allowed us in.

Methodological Problems of Working with Pilot Groups

Work with the pilot groups was ethically a difficult proposition, as we knew that we could not spend enough time with them to do much literacy work, and for some the opportunity to learn would probably not exist again in the near future. Although we had hoped to observe, rather than teach, we found that teaching was implicit in our acceptance into the group. The rapid change in our status from observers at the relatively far end of the participation continuum to full participation as teachers with virtually no time to observe was difficult. The second group made multiple demands on us, for we were not only teachers, but also mediators and sources of information about the outside world, about which they knew little but were intensely curious.

In the first group, with whom we stayed for only a few days, we could do little more than teach the reading and writing of a few numbers, which was a question of using a different medium to convey what was already familiar in the oral/aural forms. In the second group, with whom we stayed for about 4 weeks, those who progressed faster (all the women and a couple of the men) moved on to writing their names as well.

Attitudes to Literacy and Education

Parents were very concerned that we should teach their children, which we had not intended to do; for them, education was really for children, not adults. Adults identified themselves very strongly as illiterate and subconsciously seemed to think it too late to change; education was something belonging to a future generation, who would 'improve' if they had it. This, combined with their strong belief that it was not possible to learn while looking after animals—even when we had jointly proved this not to be true—were major psychological barriers to adult literacy acquisition: their self-image as pastoralists did not encompass literacy.

As we probed to find out more about where being non-literate presents problems, we found that these pastoralists were not very aware of written things around them, even when encouraged to look, and this aspect of illiteracy did not really trouble them. They were concerned with not being able to execute immediately relevant tasks such as reading bus boards, however. Each literacy activity—such as reading a bus ticket, or a bus board—was complete, and discrete in itself, and not connected together within an overarching conceptual framework of reading as a source of knowing more of the world around them. In this respect, it was not so much illiteracy *per se* that was disempowering: it was the lack of familiarity with a complex array of abilities which included formal

schooling, and learning how to interact in other formal situations. The absence of this kind of exposure was a large part of the problem of not being able to read and write.

Shifting the Research Site: from transhumant to semi-sedentary pastoralists

As luck would have it, the monsoon that year was one of the wettest of the entire century. While this ushered in a period of relative relaxation and well-being among the pastoralists, it was for us a disaster, as their departure on migration was delayed by at least 3 months; and there was no need to move together in the large groups we had experienced during the pilot season. Our best contacts all sold their animals, in itself an indication of the fragility of their occupation under present circumstances; other groups we approached were not prepared to take us, citing reasons such as the impermanence or small size of groups. Certainly, that season there were major practical hindrances, but it gradually became apparent that there was an enormous resistance to the idea of learning while migrating. This view was so widespread that we began to feel it was inappropriate to pursue it.

Any innovation necessarily entails some degree of risk-taking, and Rabaris' pragmatic response to minimising risk is to seek a successful role model who has illustrated that the innovation can work. Our work the previous season had by then not been well enough publicised to serve as a role model, and nor had we stayed long enough to help group members reach an adequate level of literacy to illustrate that what we said would happen actually did.

We were also confronted by a gap between notional and actual acceptance of education. At a notional level, education was accepted as a good thing, but since education was not available, this was generally not put to the test. Once the possibility of learning to read and write was actually available, through us, there was a choice to be made that previously did not exist. For learning to read and write to be accepted as a practical reality, compromises and adjustments had to be made. The level of acceptance of the real need for these skills was reflected in the extent to which pastoralists were prepared to adjust to allow us access to working with them. They view their work as a way of life, a vocation—and not a business; their whole identity is bound up with animal husbandry. Any attempt at introducing education or literacy is deeply disruptive because taking time out for class might jeopardise the safety of their animals, and 'without our animals, we are nothing'. We had, until then, perhaps not really understood this all-consuming focus in a pastoralist's life and its role in excluding education; we—influenced by the perceptions of their leaders—had tended to view the absence of school education and literacy in the community as a matter of logistics, but it was becoming increasingly obvious that there was a great deal more to it than this, which, as well as the climate, was working against us in our efforts to locate a new group.

Bound by the exigencies of the research schedule, we reluctantly decided that it would be a poor use of resources to push ahead with a strategy that experience was proving incompatible with the current thinking of pastoralists, especially when the groups were anyway so small. We turned instead to the semi-sedentary sub-group of Katchi Rabaris, whom we had initially discounted as they are largely sedentary and thus could make use of existing educational provision—although we knew that the quality of primary schooling is generally very low and provision of adult education non-existent. Katchis husband sheep, goats and camels, and used to migrate into Sindh, but since the Partition of India and Pakistan this route has been closed. They now engage only in local

migrations, and while this degree of sedentarisation and resultant intermingling with other social groups has had an effect on their perceptions, they share Rabari characteristics such as distinct dressing, strict adherence to a specific set of social norms, and mistrust of outsiders. In a way, working with Katchis was to foreshadow what appeared to be inevitable for the transhumant groups in the next couple of decades, for the forces pushing them towards sedentarisation seemed to be growing ever more difficult to resist.

An Experiment with REFLECT: Bhojraj wandh

We selected a research site which, as closely as possible, replicated that of the migratory *dhang*—an all-Rabari village (*wandh*) of 29 houses (two unoccupied), named Bhojraj *wandh*, where all male inhabitants were descended from the same forefather. Almost all the men had animals, but flocks were very small and generated little dairy produce; most women were doing unskilled labour for daily wages. The 119-strong population was largely non-literate, apart from one 16-year-old boy who had completed eight school grades; one adult woman, who was functionally literate; and nine adolescent girls who had completed up to four grades of school but had not reached a level of confidence in their skills to make them properly functional. All the younger children were attending the lower primary village school, although their level of proficiency was very low. A literacy course under the concurrently running national Total Literacy Campaign had lasted only a couple of days, but residents still professed interest in becoming literate.

To guide the literacy learning, we opted for the REFLECT (Regenerated Freirean Literacy Through Empowering Community Techniques) methodology advocated by ActionAid (*Education Action*, 1994; Archer & Cottingham, 1996a). We had analysed the primers of the Total Literacy Campaign in Gujarat, which we found unsuited to our needs: we do not subscribe to the 'autonomous' model of literacy (Street, 1984) which is evident in these books, and neither did we feel that the materials had been prepared according to pedagogical methods we wished to emulate. REFLECT, on the other hand, uses generative words so that letters are introduced in a context that gives them meaning and thus makes them easy to remember, and it does so via a technique that 'fuses the theory of Paulo Freire with the practice of Participatory Rural Appraisal' (Archer & Cottingham, 1996b, p. 6). It uses PRA techniques of group visualisation in mapping, matrix and calendar production, in which community knowledge is articulated and systematised (Archer & Cottingham, 1996b). This process encourages problematisation of daily reality, as Freire advocated (Freire, 1972), to promote conscientisation and the emergence of community-determined agendas for development action. REFLECT is a flexible method that draws on learners' lives as its primary resource—there are no primers—and so can be used in any context: this was the first time it has been used in Gujarat, and with pastoralists. Apart from its attractions as a teaching-learning method, the discussion methodology promised to provide us, as researchers, with plentiful data to piece together a better understanding of the ethnic identity than we could gain from interviews and participant observation.

Drawing on our previous experience of the community, we compiled a list of generative words which encompassed issues that were important in Rabari life: community organisation; animal and human resources; rainfall and drought; income and expenditure; medical issues; education; mobility; and the ideal future. In this way, the 35 consonants and 13 vowels of the Gujarati alphabet were introduced, the pace increasing as the learners grew more confident. All work was done in dialect, to stress that what is spoken can be written, which was not self-evident. Our aim was to

ensure that Rabaris were familiar with all the letters of the standard Gujarati alphabet in order that they could read them, but they do not use the full range themselves.

Attendance

Although we initially enrolled some 33 people, ten were false beginners who had already gained basic literacy skills from school, and they did not continue in our classes. Some four or five men dropped out after the first 3 days, and several other learners were erratic in attendance. We were left with a core group of 13 who made good progress. However, the extreme heat meant that animals could not be kept in village enclosures overnight, and the men reluctantly had to stop attending one month before the course was over. We were left with seven women, five of whom were really sincere, who completed the course. While this number is extremely small, it is highly significant for it is the first time that any adult literacy class has succeeded within this extremely conservative community.

Overall Progress within the 3-month Course

Initially there was some resistance to the word/theme method, as the primary school teacher uses the old alphabet method, and learners were not clear that the end effect would be the same. However, it was quickly apparent that course participants could do in a month what their children often could not do after a year. Within 2 months, learners were competent in the skills they had identified: reading bus boards and tickets; signing their names; learning numbers and how to read a clock. By then, all the letters had been introduced, and another month was devoted to consolidation and confidence-building. Learners also read texts we had written and printed, deriving from stories they had told. They did not, however, show interest in proceeding any further than this, and once we had completed the time we had initially agreed, the course ended by mutual agreement.

From their point of view, there was no real scope in their immediate environment to exercise higher levels of skills. The view was reinforced by the absence of exposure to the potential of literacy in other roles. For instance, none of those who could manage functional literacy tasks (the schooled girls) was called on to do any more than those who had just learned with us. We tried to convey the notion of the written word as a source of information, but there was no local evidence of this: they already gain all the information they require via oral sources or personal experience, so there was no call on other sources. Locally, there was an absence of any written materials even to promote casual interest: we showed them books about their bodies and they were quite amazed that such things existed. In fact, this information is partially contained in children's textbooks, but the information potential of the text had not been realised (we attribute this to the unimaginative curriculum design and tedious teaching methods that fail to relate text to real life, which do not allow a habit of reading for information to form).

This group perceived literacy as the skills of reading and writing, but only in the immediate context of tangible, immediate problems. Literacy, for them, did not encompass any abstract applications of those skills; it did not offer itself as an alternative type of language or mode of communication. Nor did it offer the promise of empowerment in socially daunting situations: this was linked with the institution of formal education, where 'how to speak' would be learned. The use of literacy was carefully limited to what was appropriate in their own daily lives, and did not serve to challenge the established oral culture, with its greater trust in the spoken word of a known person than the

information contained in an anonymous text—even when this text was designed specifically for their context.

The Development Component of REFLECT: limitations of literacy classes as a catalyst

In Bhojraj, literacy classes had very limited success in their role as a catalyst for developmentally oriented discussions. We were not really able to find the route by which to bring learners out of their immediate context towards problematising their situation constructively, and there was so little co-operation between *wandh* residents that community-based action appeared virtually impossible. The responses to two types of possible development—that by government, and self-development by co-operatives—were revealing.

Sedentary living has brought modern facilities into the Bhojraj consciousness: if other villages have electricity, roads and water, they want them too. So far, Rabaris have been a highly independent group, used to fending for themselves, but as they settle, they absorb the common perception that the state ought to provide for them; the notion of being disadvantaged, which did not occur to them before, has arisen from their comparison of what they and others have. At the same time, they do not know how to make demands on the modern state: they have never done it before; and the anonymous government apparatus is incomprehensible as they have always got their work done, visibly, via personal relationships and on an individual basis. They do not have any precedent for pressing their demands collectively, and do not connect the ability to read and write with being able to do so—this is seen as the preserve of the 'educated'. This view is borne out in the *wandh*, as the road, electricity and forthcoming water connection have been organised by the teacher. While his view was that 'if I don't work in this village nothing will happen here. Nobody will bother. No-one will ask' (personal communication, teacher Mohangiri, 26 June 1995), residents feel they have now got what they are 'entitled' to, and since the teacher is a government servant, it follows that he should do this for them. In class, they exhorted each other: 'Write as much as you can, these people will tell the government and it will all come to our village' [participant Madhuben, 27 June 1995]. Yet in general discussion, their understanding of education is consistent with their world view: an educated individual will be able to 'find his own way'—to regain independence and leave behind the dependence that illiteracy engenders.

The other option was self-development by co-operatives. Paid labour work is not available throughout the year, so an embroidery co-operative, which would supply the ready market for Rabari embroidery, would solve most labour problems for women. The notion of a co-operative already existed before our arrival, and one had already been tried, but failed for a number of reasons. It appeared to be impossible to generate enough mutual trust for a collective enterprise to function: the autonomy of the individual was so strong that no-one would be able to ask anyone else to do anything (numerous personal communications). The potential hindrance of illiteracy in terms of accounting or sales was overshadowed by realistic assessments of more pressing problems preventing change. However, participants were attracted to the possibility of setting up a co-operative shop, the first shop in the *wandh*, because it did not rely on labour input, with its possibilities for uneven inputs from different members. This seemed to have less potential for conflict than embroidery, particularly since they thought there would be no question of cheating if they could all read and write.

Adopting Education: ethnic barriers and boundaries

The vagaries of life on the move require that social identity functions at least in part as protection against the outer world, which is viewed as hostile unless it proves itself otherwise. This ethnic identity is tenaciously maintained: it divides the world into those who are Rabaris, and those who are not; the latter group is automatically met with suspicion, while the members of former are greeted as brothers, even on the very first acquaintance. Rabaris are orthodox and God-fearing; guided by strong kinship and territorial affiliations; proud of their social customs, which all have an internal logic that stems from their hereditary occupation; and highly independent and self-sufficient, with a very strong sense of the individual. While the face that is presented to the outer world is unified, the internal world with which we became familiar during the course of our research is fragmented along a number of axes which include gender, age, territorial affiliation, extent of sedentarisation, and level of education.

Our work with the nomadic groups left us with the impression that the family units retained their individuality, but worked together in a co-operative manner. There was a definite sense of community within the *dhang*: the whole group came together frequently to sing religious songs and eat together; all the women sat together in the afternoons, embroidering and chatting. This sense of harmony was absent among the semi-sedentary Bhojraj group, where we witnessed—and were part of—an evidently painful process of adjustment as present economic circumstances make it no longer possible to live apart from a world that does not share their value framework.

Fatalism and Education

Both migratory and semi-sedentary Rabaris are extremely pious, and feel their lives are guided by the Mother Goddess. Consequently, fatalism played a vital part in learners' attitudes to trying to learn to read and write: 'If you try to learn and God's grace is with you, you do learn.' Common responses to the difficulties they faced were 'God has made my brain up-side down and nothing can be done about that'; 'there is a stone in my brain so I can't understand what you are saying'; or 'I can't do it as it isn't in my fate.' Individual agency made people try, and successful progress would also be attributed in part to fate, but if for some reason they could not do things, fate rather than individual agency was the usual explanation. As facilitators, the best course was to try to create conditions in which fate was supporting their efforts: in this respect REFLECT was a good method, as it very quickly made them able to manage a little, thereby offering the hope that they would be able to do more—and thus that fate might be on their side. Again, when the weather was so unfavourable, we frequently met with the response that the Mother Goddess did not will a literacy class this year.

The Notion of 'Community'

Our experience of working within the Rabari community, especially in Bhojraj, suggests that Rabaris sustain an outwardly unified ethnic identity, but at the level of a village community this unity is highly fragmented: the nuclear family unit, and the individual self, are more important. It is as members of the ethnic group that they practise the joint religion and ceremonies which occur at the village level; not as members of a village 'community'. In such circumstances, the community-controlled development agenda REFLECT envisages is extremely hard to realise. This contrasts with findings from other

REFLECT pilot studies (Archer & Cottingham, 1996b), posing a number of questions about the efficacy of this type of literacy method (Dyer & Choksi, 1997).

The Notion of Empowerment

The notion of the non-literate as a person who is disempowered underpins all modes of thinking about illiteracy, be they from the autonomous or ideological perspectives, but our experiences with Rabaris indicates that the notion of disempowerment is extremely complex. There was a good deal of ambivalence among these pastoralists. On the one hand, there was a feeling that not having the education to 'speak' in unfamiliar social settings was disempowering: yet on the other, there was a strong sense of disdain for mainstream society, and no interest in adopting its social customs. Because they did not seek to be like others and had high self-esteem (intact, if beleaguered by messages to the contrary given out by other communities, and the educated among the Rabaris), there derived from their ethnic identity a great sense of strength and independence. They were also secure in the knowledge that, just because others do not appreciate the difficulties or type of knowledge pertaining to the work they do, that does not mean these do not exist. The absence of formal education, in that respect, did not matter at all—and in some respects, going to school would fill youngsters' heads with knowledge that was of no use, and time would be better spent learning the traditional occupation. Rabaris are also not immune to the negative examples of some of their own boys who have spent 10 years at school and fail to get work in the mainstream, but have been 'spoiled' by school and no longer have any interest in animal husbandry; and in that sense, schooling itself is disempowering.

While to the nomadic Rabaris, education represents a possible escape route to a new and better life, this life is far away and still unexperienced. Sustaining their ethnic identity within a changed social setting is a challenge that does not confront those who migrate, for whom there is little conflict between lifestyle, beliefs, or education systems—although we did have an inkling of the path that lay ahead when we were trying to negotiate access to a new group, after the pilots. To their settled counterparts, the adoption of schooling and the realisation of its future potential begin to de-legitimise a social identity that is closely bound up in the traditional occupation of animal husbandry, which is incompatible with formal schooling. Literacy/school education are seen as a panacea for difficulties in interactions with the modernising, non-Rabari world, but our experience in the *wandh* showed just how difficult it is to break into the cycle of mistrusting the outside world, and social apartness.

Remaining aloof allows security to be sustained, but at the cost of possible benefit from some of the measures which government has initiated to improve the profitability of their business (and among sedentary pastoralists, where the lifestyle has undergone such changes, the shift towards perceiving their occupation as a business has taken greater hold). When it comes to an attempt to bring the outside world into theirs, via a literacy class, mistrust of that world, and mistrust of their peers' motives, predominates. The greater diversification of the sedentary economy appears to have caused the risk factor to increase, while the imperative of school education for the survival of the next generation can no longer be ignored.

Concluding Remarks

Work among the Rabaris illustrates the complexity of the relationship between school education, literacy and development. We believe that peripatetic teaching is feasible

among Rabaris, but highly difficult. For a start, facilitators working to a finite temporal schedule broken down into days and months are not particularly compatible with Rabaris, who operate on the seasonal cycles of a lifetime. But far more complex are the social realities surrounding practices of literacy and power, and the struggles of an ethnic minority to sustain a value system ever more at odds with the modernising economy that impacts on them more and more.

At this difficult stage of transition for pastoralists, we would recommend that acquisition of literacy and informational inputs be kept separate in any programme of pastoral development. Information, and culturally sensitive, developmentally oriented inputs are urgently needed, and can surely better be provided in the Rabaris' traditional oral forum of the *diaro*, or community meeting, where participatory discussion is commonly practised. To attempt to do this via literacy classes, as we did, seems to overburden learners with an excess of novelty and to ask too much of literacy. We wonder if it might not be better to begin with participatory literacy activities around immediate functional skills learners identify, and move towards seeing the written word as a source of information—a notion that was almost totally absent in the groups we worked with—via the oral format at a later stage, once the process of conscientisation has been started through this more comfortable means. Among a group of people where there is so very little use, or even evidence of use, of the written word, literacy classes do not, in retrospect, seem a particularly appropriate medium for enhancing people's awareness of the wider world: this awareness would necessarily precede acquisition of literacy at the level where it becomes a form of social inter-communication, or an alternative form of language behaviour (Downing, 1987).

To follow the nomadic Rabaris' majority view—that formal schooling should be used as a means of ensuring literacy within the next generation—would almost inevitably mean that children have no interest in their traditional occupation, unless strenuous efforts are made to emphasise its cultural worth, and economic potential. It is unlikely that any literacy programme, however, skilfully tailored to the norms of the nomadic group, could counteract the negative associations of the nomadic way of life which have filtered into the Rabari community itself: since for them, as for others, animal husbandry and the migratory lifestyle have become virtually synonymous with social backwardness, there is not much cause for optimism on this score. It seems inevitable that unless great vision and financial support are exercised, the next couple of generations will witness Rabaris moving towards sedentary work with large animals in commercial dairy complexes, or diversifying into mainstream occupations, where they will be subject to the homogenising effect of modernisation.

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